Sun Shines Bright

Community-learned Language Models

Project Plan

Summary

Embracing grounding as a sharing and learning experience for the community over making and hacking.

Sun Shines Bright reimagines our relationship with AI and the cloud by demystifying and DIY-ing local and self-hosted AI servers, and cultivating community-led AI systems. The project proposes that grounding technology is as much about building agency and accessibility of usage for diverse creator communities as it is about the materiality of systems to build it. We propose that to "ground the cloud", we need to embody the principles of care and camaraderie in our technological interventions by:

- Creating community, agency and accessibility to use complex AI systems
- Making and hacking simple physical AI infrastructures with solar energy
- Nurturing home-grown, p2p AI servers
- Collecting and training our own Small Language Models that reflect our values and voices

Rather than naively offering alternative prototypes and end products for one-time use and showcase, we propose simple, radical ways of community building and facilitation that respond with deep, situated and diverse knowledge. We create access, agency, control and understanding of complex AI systems which, when combined with inexpensive and easy-to-use hardware, create potent critical and long-term alternatives to invasive, biased and blackbox systems. We see this effort aligned with the idea of the Solar Mamas of the Barefoot College, India, where rural women were trained in solar electrification of their villages, empowering themselves and their extended community. We envision our project having a similar ripple effect - a joyous space for knowledge building and care-forward tinkering with technology.

Premise and Urgent Context

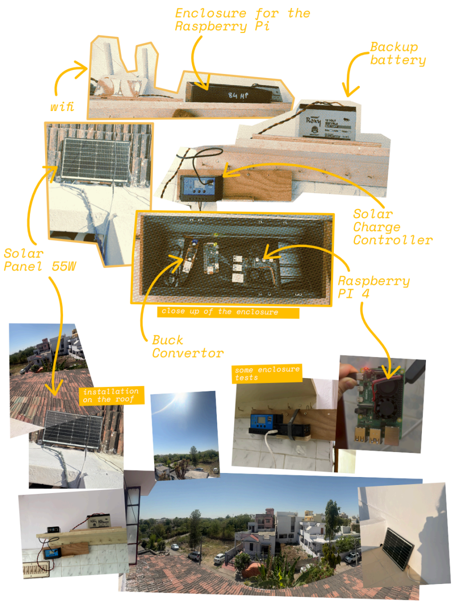
Contemporary life is inextricably linked to massively scaled AI systems trained on biased datasets and hosted in energy-intensive data centers. **As an alternative, *can community-learned, solar-powered small language models create new forms of technological intimacy that resist extraction while fostering care?***

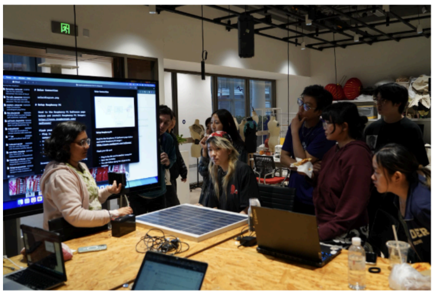
Inspired by Solar Protocol, which they call 'A Naturally Intelligent Network', **Sun Shines Bright's proof of concept simultaneously explores low-energy and sustainable**

model hosting and opportunities and efficacies of Small Language Models. The early experiments (Jan-Mar 2025) and subsequent workshop at NYU Shanghai (April 2025) proved that building a simple solar-powered server for hosting AI models is not only possible but can be easily shared and explored with students and creatives from non-technology backgrounds. This was followed up by an exhibit and zine about Sun Shines Bright at [AIxDESIGN Festival: On Slow AI](), May 2025 and [Chaos Feminist Convention]() July 2025. Several feminist non-technologist creators have expressed their interest in building their own solar servers. This reflects an urgent need for:

- agency over the mainstream high-power black-boxed AI systems
- dissociation and simple solutions from current cloud-based models,

These models are climatically problematic and also do not reflect critical feminist non-white data. **Now more than ever, we need camaraderie, friendship and intimacy as pillars of building agency and ease around fast-paced complex AI systems.**





What we will do

How does owning and shaping a language model versus using cloud-based systems fundamentally alter our relationship with AI technology?

We propose that Sun Shines Bright becomes a space to empower community-led small language model creation and hosting.

The proposal consists of 3 phases, of which Phase 2 is the most important.

PHASE I: Technical Grounding (3-4 months)

Solar Infrastructure Development

- 1-2 solar server installations as proof of concept
- Testing optimal configurations for LLM hosting
- Creating replicable, scalable solar setups
- Documentation of power requirements and seasonal variations

Language Model Experimentation

- Testing and Fine-tuning small language models with community datasets
- Developing local hosting solutions
- Creating accessible interfaces for non-developers
- Building step-by-step guides that demystify the process
- Developing data preparation tools with friendly interfaces

Partners

- Solar Protocol (technical advisory on power/installation/scalability)
- Ajaibghar (feminist technology context and implementation)
- HEAD Geneva (tutorials for SLM fine-tuning)
- Dr. Selena Savic (de-colonizing AI perspectives)

PHASE II: Community Cultivation (3-4 months)

Workshop Design & Facilitation

- Context-setting sessions on decolonial technology practices
- Hands-on SLM creation workshops
- Participants' profile: tech-curious, open to non-colonial perspectives, eager to explore new narratives
- 2-3 participants will self-host their own solar-powered LLMs in homes/studios

Community Building Principles

- Grounding practices in non-colonial feelings of shared resources
- Building intimacy with technology while building intimacy with community
- Exploring how AI can (or cannot) serve low-resource language communities
- Creating spaces for critical dialogue about translating ideas across power structures

Partners

- AIxDesign (local creator networks, space access, slow AI formats)
- Ajaibghar (feminist tech context, community of creators, non-mainstream capacity building)
- Dr. Selena Savic (local student network)

PHASE III: Sustaining and Sharing (2 months)

Documentation

- Solar-hosted documentation (on web)
- Small Language Model hosting process, community stories, technical and DIY tips
- Follow-up support for self-hosted installations (till 4-6 months after Phase 2 ends)
- Interface tools for data preparation and model training

Knowledge Sharing Infrastructure

- Developing DIY Solar-powered Small Language Model
- Hosting Open-source documentation

Partners

- Ajaibghar (Documentation, Hosting)
- Dr. Selena Savic (de-colonizing AI perspectives)

Expected Outcomes & Impact

1. Tangible Infrastructure: 2-3 functional solar-powered LLM installations in Randstad region demonstrating viable alternatives to cloud computing
2. Empowered Community: 15+ trained community members capable of creating, hosting, and maintaining their own language models
3. Online tutorial: 50-100 people will access this tutorial in the time period of project through HEAD Geneve's network
4. Open Knowledge Base: Comprehensive documentation enabling adaptation
5. Cultural Shift: Demonstrated proof that AI development can be intimate, ecological, and community-owned
6. Network Effects: Collaboration with international and NL-based partners

Closing Vision

Computational Mama's community-oriented capacity-building tech practice centers around care and community. While it is important to share and build prototypes, it is equally important to build inclusive spaces for creators to understand, make, and feel agency around what AI and language models can mean to their practice.

Working with tinker-ability allows for improved intimacy with closed, inaccessible and blackbox technology. It is necessary for explorative and creative practices to be situated in care to address the long-term impact of ecological and social impact of technology. **Sun Shines Bright isn't just about solar panels or language models, it's about building a critical relationship with new technology.**

Partners

Solar Protocol - Their expertise guides sustainable energy solutions for AI infrastructure. They provide technical advisory on solar power installations, scalability, and optimal configurations for hosting a Small Language Model.

Ajaibghar - Led by Computational Mama and Nanditi Khilnani, they bring feminist technology context and implementation throughout all phases of the project. They provide non-mainstream capacity building, and handle documentation hosting during Phase III.

HEAD Geneva - They offer tutorials and guidance for Small Language Model fine-tuning during Phase I - technical development. They also provide access to their network, enabling 50-100 people to access online tutorials during the project period.

AIxDesign **-** They offer local creator networks, space access, and slow AI formats for Phase II - community cultivation. They bring proven experience in facilitating inclusive spaces aligned with the project's community-centered approach.

Dr. Selena Savić (University of Amsterdam) - They contribute decolonizing-AI perspectives and critical academic insight during technical grounding, and also provide access to local student networks during Phase II - workshops.

Creative Coding Utrecht **-** They collaborate for facilitation of the Small Language Model(SLM) coding workshops and also bring tech materials for using in the workshops around building the SLM installations.